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Applying Classic Grounded Theory in a complex intervention: from open to theoretical sampling

Method focus: sampling, comparison and theorising in a nursing-home Magnet Model feasibility project

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Key message: Classic Grounded Theory helped us initiate and follow up a complex intervention from broad exploration to targeted theoretical sampling, while keeping the analysis grounded in participants' perspectives.

BACKGROUND

Recruiting and retaining registered nurses (RNs) in elderly care is an increasing challenge. This study forms part of a larger project exploring whether the Magnet Model can strengthen nursing practice and create attractive work environments in nursing homes. The initial focus was to understand what enables RNs to thrive in their roles.

OBJECTIVE

The objective was to present methodological challenges and opportunities associated with applying Classic Grounded Theory as a study design in the context of a complex intervention.

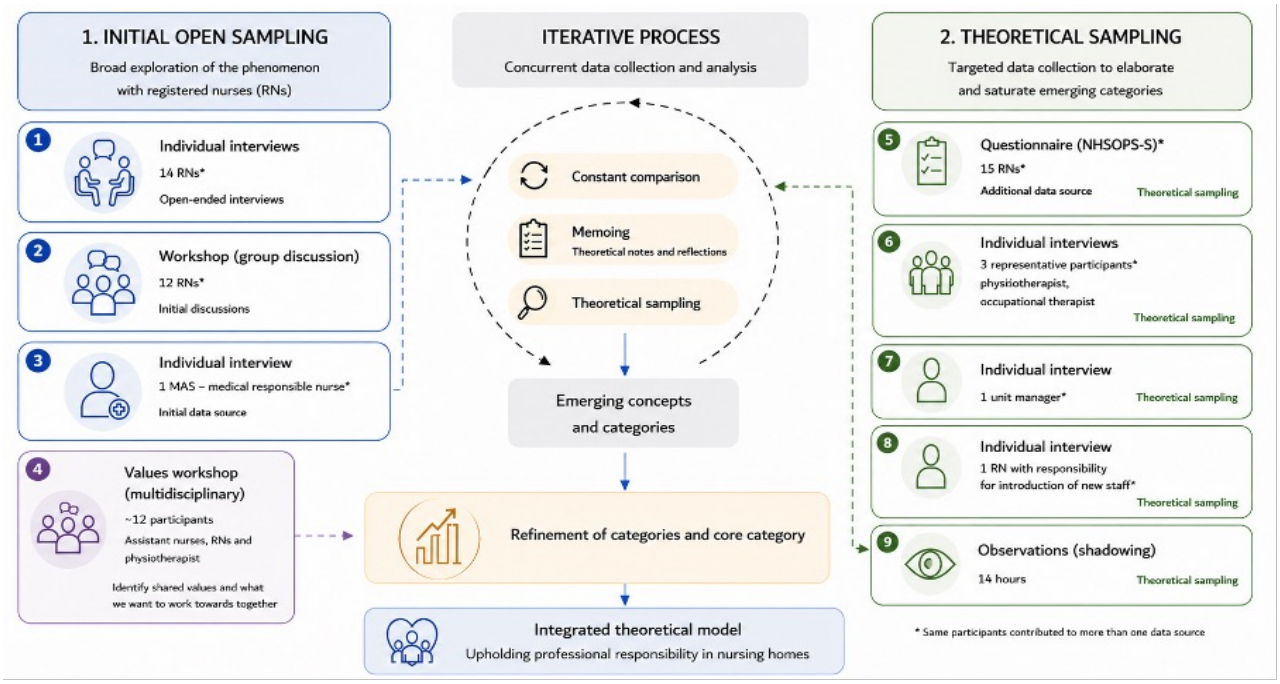
DESIGN, SETTING and METHOD

This Classic Grounded Theory study was conducted in two Swedish nursing homes during 2023–2026.

The method was chosen to explore RNs' main concerns and its strength in explaining social processes, handling rich data and supporting iterative sampling over time.

Collecting Data and Constant Comparative Analysis – An Iterative Process

"All is data"
/Glaser



Open question: *"Can you tell me about your experiences of working as an RN in a nursing home?"* **Theoretical question:** *"How is quality upheld in everyday nursing practice?"*

DISCUSSION OF THE METHOD

Opportunities

- Flexibility to follow the intervention and the related problems as it unfolded.
- Iterative sampling across multiple data sources supported theory generation.
- Constant comparison and memoing kept the analysis close to participants' perspectives.

Challenges

- Theorising was the demanding step: lifting analysis from patterns to explanations and abstraction.
- Repeated decisions were needed about when and why to sample next data.
- The methodological route had to be made transparent for validity and a multidisciplinary audience.

Take-home conclusion: Classic Grounded Theory was suitable for generating valuable knowledge about the concerns and problems emerging related to this complex intervention. The method allowed continuous sampling over time and led to an integrated theoretical model explaining the main concern of ensuring high-quality care within a fragmented organisational context. However, the movement from description to theory must be shown clearly.

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